

After the air strikes: Did NATO bomb Serbia to force its accession?

The consequences of the air strikes against Yugoslavia, which followed NATO's usual practice of spreading peace and democracy by force worldwide, can be seen 20 years later not only in Serbia, but also in the global geopolitical strategies of the major powers and their allies.

However, some of the goals of the Western forces, for which the alliance fought a sovereign state with weapons, have not yet been achieved.

In 1999, [NATO bombed Serbia for 78 days](#). The exact number of victims of the alliance's air operation was not officially released, but Serbian estimates suggest [that between 1,200 and 2,500 people were killed](#) and around 6,000 injured. NATO bombs destroyed infrastructure, industrial facilities, schools, hospitals, cultural monuments, churches and monasteries, and residential buildings. NATO aircraft not only reduced Serbian cities to rubble but also devastated the Serbian economy. According to various estimates in Belgrade, the economic damage amounted to between 30 and 100 billion dollars. But no less important are the political and geopolitical consequences of the bombing of Yugoslavia. According to the former Prime Minister of the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia, Momir Bulatovic, the attack against Serbia without the approval of the UN Security Council paved the way for endless wars and violations of international law by the USA and its allies.

"I would like to remind everyone that the Americans openly stated at the time that they could fight four wars simultaneously. They claimed they could attack Iraq, Libya, and North Korea at the same time as us. We became the first target because they had the Kosovo Liberation Army here, which meant they didn't have to worry about a ground operation. When the Americans finished with us, they moved on – a series of uninterrupted wars followed," said Bulatovic.

According to him, it was precisely the bombing raids on Yugoslavia that became the driving force behind Russia's return to the "Great Game." "Most important to me are the words of Vladimir Putin, who said several times that Russia came to its senses when it saw NATO destroying Belgrade and all of Serbia. This had serious consequences not only for us, but for peace throughout the world," Bulatovic said.

Political scientist Leon Kojen believes that the NATO attack on Yugoslavia had less obvious goals besides the overthrow of Slobodan Milosevic.



“Two of these main tasks are quite obvious: firstly, of course, the international recognition of Kosovo. The second goal, which for understandable reasons was not so obvious immediately after the air strikes, but became increasingly apparent over time, was to make Serbia a NATO member so that it would lose the independence that Belgrade still possesses today,” the expert said.

Political scientist Slobodan Samardzic explains to Sputnik why neither of the two strategic goals of the US and its allies can be considered fully achieved even after 20 years:

" [Kosovo has not yet achieved independence](#) . It lacks the most important element – legal independence, which Pristina can only obtain once Serbia legally recognizes Kosovo. This poses the risk of a legally binding agreement on the so-called comprehensive normalization of relations. Even then, Kosovo would still not be independent; its independence would depend on Serbia."

According to Kojen, given how long and persistently the West has pursued its goals in the Balkans, it would be naive to believe that it will deviate from its Balkan strategy:

“In my opinion, the West should not be expected to give up after 20 years of persistent work to achieve these goals, no matter how deep its political crisis. Although the world is now much closer to multipolarity than in 1999, it seems

to me that these goals will not disappear and the Belgrade authorities will have to confront them sooner or later," the expert said.

According to experts, Serbia's situation has long been complicated by the "EU above all" maxim proclaimed by local politicians, a maxim that has clearly lost relevance recently as Serbia's prospects for EU accession have diminished in recent years. How should Serbia behave to preserve its independence from NATO's will, withstand the enormous pressure of being forced to relinquish some of its territory, and defend its own national interests?

According to Kojen, Belgrade should stop "bribing" the EU in exchange for the hope of joining and defend its own interests using accessible means:

"Serbia always has the chance to change its foreign policy direction if it wants to. This isn't easy, given that Serbia is now surrounded by NATO members, and this isn't likely to change in the near future. However, the world is indeed much closer to a multipolar system today than it was 20 or 30 years ago. A sensible shift in foreign policy, guided solely by the national interests and historical values of Serbia and the Serbian people, would at least allow us some improvements," the expert said.